PHOTOGRAPHS BY WALTER HALL

Kitless Ebonite rollerball

In this issue, **Walter Hall** makes a kitless Ebonite rollerball pen

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The kitless fountain pen I made in *Woodturning* 287 and 288 involved working with aluminium, using expensive triple start taps and dies imported from the USA and a Bock nib unit with special tap. All of this expense and complexity might have given the impression that making kitless pens is a dark art, restricted to the rich and highly skilled turner. In this article I intend to disprove this by showing how to make a simple rollerball pen using only the taps and dies that might be found in a relatively cheap set, of the type commonly sold in discount supermarkets and DIY stores and turned from the much more forgiving medium of Ebonite.

On his occasion I have incorporated a clip salvaged from a Taylors Mirfield Omega pen kit, a small spring from my spares box and a rollerball refill from Beaufort Ink. All the other components are made on the lathe from Ebonite, a hard rubber material used for making ten-pin bowling balls, vintage-style pens and the stems of tobacco pipes.

Before going on to the step-by-step process, I would firstly like to thank all of those readers who responded to my request in a previous article and offered suggestions for holding taps on the lathe in a way that would ensure accuracy. I received several responses, some of them very ingenious and all of them practical. In the end, I opted to purchase a relatively inexpensive drill chuck tapping attachment from RDG Tools, suggested to me by Geoffrey Laycock. This consists of a chuck mounted on a spindle which slides in a hollow Morse taper. The work is turned by means of a tommy bar through the spindle against the workpiece, which is held in the locked headstock spindle (see step 9).

EQUIPMENT AND MATERIALS USED

Ebonite rods
Engineers jaws, pen blank jaws or pin jaws
M10 x 1.25 die
Drill
3mm drill bit
4.8mm drill bit
6.5mm drill bit
Scrap acrylic
60° revolving centre
Abrasive
6mm BSP thread
6mm BSP nuts
Clip and refill for pen
Thin parting tool
Adjustable pen mandrel
Cone bushing
Threaded mandrel
Spindle gouge/skew chisel
Tripoli and white diamond compounds

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